THIS WEEK'S FILE · FOUNDER FILE #007

MARC LOU AND THE PORTFOLIO FACTORY: MANY FAILURES, ONE BOILERPLATE, THEN SUBSCRIPTIONS

A French developer was fired, moved to Bali with about $20,000, and shipped product after product in public. His own figures show a million-dollar year, a hit that has faded by about 80 percent, and a pivot to subscriptions. Here is what is verified, what isn't, and what you can copy.

THE FILE

FOUNDER	Marc Lou (Marc Louvion), Solo founder
COMPANY	ShipFast, CodeFast, DataFast and TrustMRR
FOUNDED	2023 (ShipFast)
HQ	Remote
SECTOR	Developer tools, courses and analytics
STAGE	Bootstrapped, solo
FUNDING	None reported
MODEL	One-time products shifting to subscriptions and a marketplace

Hello again, and welcome to File #007. Thank you for reading.

In November 2021, a French marketer was fired from a job working for an internet influencer. He had about $20,000 and no plan, so he moved to Bali and started building things. Two years later he had launched somewhere between 16 and 17 products, and, in September 2023, the one that finally paid: a code template for developers called ShipFast.

His name is Marc Lou, and he publishes his revenue more openly than almost anyone. That makes him a good subject for this series, and also an awkward one, because the numbers are still his own, and some of the most interesting ones sit inside products he owns. We'll show you the full picture. (All figures are in US dollars. Every one is self-reported unless we

say otherwise.)

THE SHORT VERSION

- **Who:** Marc Louvion, known online as Marc Lou, a French solo founder who builds in public.
- **What:** a portfolio of small products. ShipFast is a Next.js starter kit that saves developers weeks of setup. CodeFast is a course for beginners. DataFast is analytics that show which traffic sources produce paying customers. TrustMRR is a database of verified startup revenue that has grown into a marketplace for buying and selling startups.
- **Why it matters:** it is the clearest worked example of a portfolio approach, where most things fail, a few work, and you move your effort to whatever is growing.
- **The number to remember:** about 80 percent. That's the drop in ShipFast's monthly revenue between December 2025 and mid-2026, on figures from his own Stripe-connected dashboard. The founder is fine. The product that made him famous is fading, and that is the story.

THE FOUNDER

Before ShipFast, by his own telling, he spent about four years on side projects that never reached $3,000 a month. His site says that in 2018 he spent a year building a startup that got zero users, then burned out. After the 2021 firing and the move to Bali he began posting his work publicly on X. By December 2023 the products were reportedly bringing in about $65,000 a month with no employees.

Two facts about how he works matter more than the headlines.

He treats products as temporary. His rule is to ship small, see whether anyone pays, and cut the rest. His own 2025 recap lists launches that failed. BioAge and ClipMarc did not work. When he built the idea that became TrustMRR, he tried ten different verticals and nine failed before one worked.

He builds in the open and uses his audience as distribution. He says his newsletter reached 51,234 readers by January 2026, and that 100,000 new followers joined him on X during 2025. He also earned $14,339 from X itself in 2025.

THE PRODUCT THAT MADE HIM: SHIPFAST

ShipFast launched on 1 September 2023 as a Next.js starter kit: the sign-in, payments, emails, database and landing page that nearly every web app needs, ready to use. The idea came from something he had done again and again. By his account he had rebuilt the same handful of pieces from scratch for around 16 earlier products, and then packaged them.

It sold once, not monthly. One-off purchases were priced at $49 and $69 at launch. The page now shows $199 to $249 (it also offers a bundle with his course). It claims 8,445 "makers" as

customers, and a Discord of 5,000 or more. Starter Story reported that it made about $528,000 in its first four months, and Streakr, quoting the founder, puts the launch month at about $40,000.

By his own page, ShipFast has taken in about $1.09 million in total. TrustMRR, which verifies revenue directly from the payment processor, shows about $1.27 million. He hasn't explained the gap of roughly $180,000, and both are systems he runs.

WHAT HAPPENED TO SHIPFAST

One-off products follow a curve. There is a launch wave, a tail fed by the founder's audience, and then a decline as the content ages and the market fills with alternatives. Here is the monthly record, from his own Stripe-connected dashboard as shown on TrustMRR:

MONTH	SHIPFAST	CODEFAST	DATAFAST	TRUSTMRR
December 2025	$20,281	$22,267	$16,187	$22,883
March 2026	$9,463	$8,268	$21,306	$31,921
June 2026	$3,338	$9,788	$21,487	$28,603
July 2026	$4,832	$6,682	$27,158	$42,373

In the thirty days to 11 August 2026, ShipFast made $3,537. The one-time products are shrinking and the subscription and marketplace products are taking over, which is exactly the move he set out to make.

THE SHIFT TO SUBSCRIPTIONS

DataFast helps site owners see which sources of traffic actually bring paying customers. In his 2025 recap he put it at $15.8K in monthly recurring revenue, heading towards about 1,000 paying customers, with roughly 7 percent monthly churn and 14 percent month-on-month growth. It took about four months to reach its first $1,000. A big part of its growth, he says, is that users share screenshots of their analytics.

TrustMRR came from a different frustration: fake revenue screenshots. It shows startups' revenue verified through payment providers such as Stripe, and it grew into a marketplace where startups can be bought and sold. He built the first version in about 24 hours. By his account it reached $25,000 a month within days, the marketplace launched in December 2025, and a dozen startups were acquired in the first two weeks. (The Stripe timeline shows its first revenue in October 2025 and $22,883 in December, so "within days" is probably a loose description.) By July 2026 it was his largest line.

His total monthly revenue in the first half of 2026 appears in his own updates at roughly $80,000 to $100,000, though sources disagree by month. In 2025 as a whole he reported $1,032,000, which he says is 20 percent less than 2024. It is a good business, and a smaller one than the year before.

WHAT YOU NEED TO KNOW ABOUT THE NUMBERS

This is the part to read carefully.

- **All of it is self-reported.** It comes from his posts, his newsletter, his website and his dashboards.
- **He owns the verifier.** TrustMRR is the tool he built to prove revenue, it is now his biggest earner, and his own figures are verified through it. That doesn't make anything false, and it does mean there's no independent check.
- **Headline versus recurring.** His page has shown about $108,000 a month as a headline, while his dashboard showed about $43,800 in true monthly recurring revenue. The gap is mostly one-time sales, which have to be re-won every month. Always ask which kind of number you're looking at.
- **A different story in different places.** One snapshot of his page in January 2025 showed $182,100 a month. His January 2026 newsletter says 2025 totalled $1,032,000, which averages about $86,000 a month. The two are measuring different things, and we couldn't reconcile them.

WHAT ABOUT THE AI?

It is often said that Marc uses AI coding tools such as Cursor, and the idea is plausible. But we could not find it confirmed in anything he has written. His 2025 recap doesn't mention AI tools at all apart from an investment, and the sources that describe his Cursor and Claude set-up are undated and low quality. We would rather say that than repeat it.

What can be said is that his products are about shipping with modern tools, and that his own method, rapid small builds judged by whether people pay, suits an era where building is cheap. The scarce thing, by his own account, is the audience.

THE SECURITY EPISODE

In October 2024 other developers publicly reported security flaws in some of his products, including one called IndiePage. Indie Hackers reported that his first public response was dismissive, saying that dozens of people try to break his sites every day. After community criticism and a community security audit, he published an apology two days later. We could not confirm which specific fixes shipped or whether existing buyers received them.

It's a useful lesson for anyone shipping fast. A product aimed at developers and sold on speed can lose trust quickly if it appears careless.

Try this

Package the thing you've built three times. Look at the last few projects you've done. What did you rebuild from scratch each time? That is a product, and the people you build for will probably be the first to buy it.

Keep a kill list. Decide in advance how long a new product gets and what it has to earn. Marc tried ten versions of one idea before one worked, and he published the failures.

Plan for the curve. If you sell one-off products, assume revenue decays and start the recurring product early. His portfolio moved before the old product collapsed.

Separate the number from the verifier. If you publish revenue, use a verification method you don't own, or say clearly that you own it.

WHAT COULD GO WRONG

The audience is the asset. ShipFast, CodeFast and DataFast all depend on his X following and newsletter. If his reach falls, or X changes, the whole portfolio feels it.

One-off products decay. His biggest hit is now a small line. Whether DataFast and TrustMRR can replace it, and keep growing, is the open question.

A marketplace has to be trusted. TrustMRR's value depends on being believed. An error, a disputed listing or a questioned conflict of interest could hurt it quickly.

Speed versus trust. The 2024 episode showed how fast a reputation for shipping quickly can turn into one for shipping carelessly.

Most experiments fail, including his. The recap says so, and it is the most honest line in his own writing.

WHAT TO WATCH

1. **Whether subscription revenue keeps growing** as ShipFast declines, and whether total monthly revenue stays near $80,000 to $100,000.
2. **TrustMRR's marketplace.** Do deals complete, and does anyone question how it is run?
3. **An independent check.** Does anyone outside his own systems confirm the numbers?
4. **The next product.** In 2025 he mentioned a project he hadn't launched. Is it another one-off, or another subscription?

A French marketer was fired, moved to Bali, and kept shipping. Some of it worked, some of it stopped working, and he told you both. That openness is the thing you can copy first.

That's File #007. Thank you for reading it. If it made you think of someone, forward it along, and if there's a founder you'd like to see opened next, tell us at info@aifounderfiles.com. File #008 lands next Sunday.

Where this came from: Marc Lou's own newsletter, website and dashboards, plus press and compilations we label as secondary. We have not verified any revenue figure independently. Claude, made by Anthropic, helped research and draft this file. Spotted a mistake? Email info@aifounderfiles.com and we'll correct it.

SOURCES

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- Security bugs engulf ShipFast, a popular indie hacker's product, in drama, Indie Hackers (October 2024). indiehackers.com
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